UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA, LOS ANGELES **UCLA**

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CENTER FOR DIGITAL HUMANITIES
1020 PUBLIC AFFAIRS BUILDING
LOS ANGELES, CALIFORNIA 90095-1499
PHONE: (310) 206-1414

February 2, 2026

To the committee:

I am delighted to write this letter nominating Arpit Gaind for the Teaching and Learning Center's Distinguished Teaching Award for teaching assistants. I am the faculty coordinator of an undergraduate cluster course called Data, Justice, and Society (DJS). For the last two years, Arpit has served as a TA for DJS for the entire academic year, so I have had numerous opportunities to discuss teaching with Arpit and to observe his interactions with students.

Arpit is a dedicated, thoughtful, and incredibly conscientious teacher. He has sought out numerous opportunities to develop his teaching skills, including frequent consultations with the cluster's writing coordinator and a graduate certificate in Writing Pedagogy. At our weekly teaching team meetings, Arpit has consistently impressed me with his acute observations and ideas. He frequently anticipates potential pitfalls in assignments, suggests ways to simplify complex ideas, and points out methods for engaging students.

Arpit often develops teaching resources like worksheets and activity plans that he shares with the entire team. For example, this week students told us that they were struggling to translate their research ideas into workable questions. In response, Arpit shared a brainstorming template that carefully guides students toward clarity in content, methods, and feasibility.

In our discussions about particular students, Arpit demonstrates great sensitivity, professionalism, and judgment. In one case, we grew concerned that a student was using an LLM to generate their written assignments. Rather than confronting the student with a list of suspicions, Arpit met with them at length, engaging them in a searching conversation about methods, sources, and research. Listening carefully and without judgment, Arpit helped the student understand how to develop their own ideas and overcome roadblocks that had prevented the student from making progress.

This spring, Arpit will teach the second iteration of a critical media literacy class that he has developed independently, with meticulous attention to scaffolding assignments and drawing on research-based pedagogical methods. Students tell us that this seminar is an incredibly valuable addition to their intellectual progress.

Over the last two years, Arpit has become a valued colleague whose opinion I frequently solicit. I am very grateful for the opportunity to teach alongside him, and I warmly recommend him for

the DTA.

Please contact me at mposner@humnet.ucla.edu if further details would be helpful

Sincerely,



Miriam Posner
Associate Professor
Department of Information Studies
University of California, Los Angeles

Nominee Statement Arpit Gaind

PhD Candidate and Teaching Fellow,

Cluster 10, Data, Justice and Society, and TAC, WAC/D

Affective Classroom: **Pedagogy to Practice**

My teaching philosophy rests on a simple premise: the classroom is not a static container for information, but a rehearsal space for the world. Beginning my career in Delhi's theater spaces ten years ago, I learned that engagement requires *presence*—the ability to read a room, adapt to energy levels, and make the audience a co-creator. Today, as a PhD candidate, I have translated those theatrical instincts into a rigorous, evidence-based pedagogy. Whether teaching the technical intricacies of *Video Production (WAC 80)* or dismantling post-colonial theory in *Critical Media Literacy (10CW)*, my goal is to move students from passive consumption to active knowledge construction. This shift is critical: it transforms the instructor from a gatekeeper of knowledge into a facilitator of discovery, where students learn to trust their own intellectual instincts.

However, I recognize that *presence* requires safety. In lab-based courses, I often encounter technical anxiety, where students from non-arts backgrounds find software like Adobe Premiere intimidating. To dismantle this, I implement "Mood and Thought Check-ins" at the start of every session, diagnostic tools that acknowledge learning as an affective process. Crucially, I make a point of ensuring students do not feel judged for what they do not know; instead, I encourage them to speak with confidence even when they are unsure. This strategy has yielded tangible results; in recent course evaluations, students consistently noted that this

environment “removed the fear of failure,” allowing them to focus on “storytelling.” During a module on “Sound and Power,” rather than lecturing on how audio editing manipulates truth, I pivoted to an impromptu activity where students edited a raw interview clip into two opposing narratives solely by changing the sound design. By treating the classroom as a practice space, I ensure students feel safe enough to fail and eventually see these tools not as obstacles but as palettes for their own stories.

Collaborative Praxis: Scaffolding Public Scholarship

My pedagogical approach has been most deeply refined during my two-year tenure in the *UCLA Cluster Program.* This interdisciplinary environment requires a level of coordination rare in graduate pedagogy. Working closely with the Writing Instruction team, I opened my classroom to regular observation and curriculum review. This transparency, having my lesson plans scrutinized by experts in writing pedagogy, allowed me to fine-tune my methods in real time. For instance, after observing student struggles with essay structure, I collaborated with the writing team to integrate the “Keyhole Diagram,” a structural heuristic that helps students visualize their arguments. The adaptability has been further tested through my work teaching a diverse range of international students in Summer Sessions. In the Spring 2025 seminar, I furthered this commitment by guiding students in creating comprehensive Digital Portfolios for their finals, complementing this with exit reflection essays and enacting the politics of representation through video essays and multimedia blogs. The recommendations accompanying this application—from the writing specialists who observed this evolution and the students who thrived within it—are a testament to this collaborative ethos.

Beyond the Classroom: **Institutional Leadership**

Finally, I believe effective teaching extends beyond the classroom into the institutional structures that shape student life. My pedagogical reach has expanded through significant leadership roles, theoretically grounded in my Graduate Certificates in Writing Pedagogy and Digital Humanities and my training at the *UCLA Leadership Academy*. As Chair of the *UCLA Communications Board,* I mentor undergraduate editors across 11 campus publications. In this capacity, I do not just oversee operations; I teach students to navigate media ethics and governance in real time. Similarly, I am committed to demystifying the hidden curriculum of academia for my peers. As Chair of the *CISA Graduate Conference (2025-26)* and editor for *Comitatus*, I guide fellow graduate students through the rigorous processes of academic publishing. Additionally, as the departmental Teaching Assistant Consultant (TAC), I mentor incoming TAs on facilitating difficult conversations. This mentorship has proven vital; peer feedback from these workshops indicates that new instructors feel significantly more capable of managing classroom dynamics after our sessions.

This extensive portfolio, ranging from intimate seminar rooms to complex administrative boards, has profoundly shaped my own growth. I am deeply grateful to have experienced such diversity and a spectrum of teaching profiles at UCLA. Navigating these varied spaces has enriched my scholarly and personal experience, teaching me that education is not a destination but a daily, iterative work of improvement, one that requires constant listening, adapting, and rehearsing.

Statement of Teaching Philosophy

Arpit Gaind, PhD Candidate

Department of World Arts and Cultures/Dance

From Consumption to Production: A Pedagogy of Critical Making

In the twenty-first century, students are immersed in a level of digital saturation unprecedented in human history. They arrive in my classroom having consumed thousands of hours of visual media, yet they often lack the tools to deconstruct the architecture of that consumption. As a teacher of Visual Anthropology and Media Production, my primary pedagogical goal is not merely to transfer technical skills, but to transform students from passive consumers into ethical, critical producers who can navigate and intervene in the complex, algorithmic media ecologies that define their daily lives. I operate on the conviction that making is a form of thinking. Whether I am teaching the mechanics of Adobe Premiere Pro or the post-colonial theories of representation, I dissolve the artificial boundary between theory and practice. My philosophy is built upon three methodological pillars: Affective Accessibility, Metacognitive Scaffolding, and Critical Making. These pillars are designed to dismantle specific barriers to learning: technical anxiety, structural vagueness, and the disconnect between academic concepts and lived experience.

I. Affective Accessibility: Lowering the Cognitive Barrier

Learning is an embodied, affective process. In my production-based course, *WAC 80: Video Tools*, I frequently encounter technical anxiety among students from humanities backgrounds, who view software as opaque and intimidating. Pedagogically, I treat this anxiety not as a personality trait but as a cognitive barrier; high stress creates an affective filter that

blocks the absorption of new information. To lower this filter, I operationalize care through Mood and Thought Check-ins. While these function socially as icebreakers, analytically, they are diagnostic tools. They allow me to read the room's affective climate and adjust my pedagogy in real-time. For example, when a check-in reveals collective exhaustion, I shift from "Lecture-Demo" to "Follow-Along" formats, slowing the pace to reduce cognitive load. This is not about coddling students; it is about rigorous accessibility. My evaluations confirm that when students feel psychologically safe, when the fear of breaking the machine is removed, they are able to engage in higher-order creative risk-taking. By curating the emotional environment, I ensure that the technology becomes a tool for expression rather than a source of alienation.

II. Metacognitive Scaffolding: Visualizing Argumentation

In writing-intensive seminars like *10CW: Critical Media Literacy*, the challenge is often epistemological: students struggle to translate their passionate, intuitive ideas into structured academic arguments. My philosophy posits that writing is a design process that requires visualization. To teach this, I move beyond abstract advice (e.g., "be more specific") and utilize Visual Heuristics, specifically the "Keyhole Diagram." This method treats the essay not as a stream of consciousness, but as an architectural structure. We use the diagram to reverse-engineer complex theoretical texts (e.g., Stuart Hall), mapping the author's moves to demystify how theory is constructed. When students apply this to their own work, the diagram acts as a pre-writing constraint, forcing them to visualize the connection between their specific evidence (the body) and their broader social significance (the opening). This moves the student from summarizing content to analyzing structure. The success of this method is evident in the high conversion rate of my students from summary-based drafts to thesis-driven final papers. It

demonstrates that when we make the hidden logic of academic writing visible, students can master it.

III. Critical Making: Enacting Theory

My final pillar, Practice-as-Research, is grounded in the belief that students understand power dynamics best when they must enact them. It is one thing to critique how the media manipulates truth; it is another to be the manipulator. In my curriculum, I replace passive observation with active interference. In my "Sound and Power" module, students are tasked with editing a neutral interview clip into opposing narratives, solely through sound design. This exercise anchors the abstract concept of media framing in a tangible, somatic experience. Students realize the power of an editor not through a textbook definition, but by recognizing that a single sound effect can alter the truth. I assess this through Digital Portfolios, moving away from disposable assignments toward public-facing scholarship. This shift to a public audience fundamentally alters the stakes of assessment. When students know their work will be viewed beyond the instructor—by peers, future employers, or community members—they engage more deeply with the ethics of their curation. By asking students to curate their work for a public audience, I align my teaching with the principles of Visual Sovereignty, empowering them to take ownership of their creation.

IV. Institutional Praxis: The Community of Practice

Finally, I believe that a teaching philosophy must extend beyond the individual classroom to the department and university as a whole. Pedagogy is not a solitary act; it is a community practice. As the Teaching Assistant Coordinator (TAC), I view mentorship as a form of "institutional care," a commitment to creating structures that sustain the labor of teaching and make it collaborative. My approach to mentoring new TAs mirrors my approach to students: I

aim to make the “hidden curriculum” transparent. For example, I recently mentored a junior TA who felt overwhelmed by the silence in their discussion sections. Rather than offering generic advice, we collaborated to co-develop a “low-stakes” participation rubric and a series of scaffolded community-building activities. This intervention did more than fix a classroom dynamic; it empowered the TA to find their own administrative voice, demonstrating that pedagogical authority is constructed through design, not just intuition. This praxis extends to my work with undergraduate student media. Rather than viewing governance as mere administration, I approach it as a real-time curriculum on media ethics. By treating every editorial crisis as a teachable moment, I ensure that student editors do not just manage publications, they internalize the ethical weight of public speech. By fostering a culture where pedagogical challenges are shared rather than privatized, I ensure that the next cohort of instructors and creators is equipped with the empathy, structure, and practical tools necessary to serve UCLA’s diverse community.

Selected Artifacts with Annotations

Arpit Gaind, PhD Candidate

Cluster 10, Data Justice and Society

Program Coordinator: Prof. Miriam Posner

Artifact 1: Artifact 1: Affective Diagnostics – The "Mood and Thought Check-in"

- **Connection to statement:** As described in the "Affective Classroom" section, I open every session with this diagnostic tool. It operationalizes my philosophy that presence requires safety. By asking students to visualize their mental state, I can assess the room's energy and adjust my pacing in real-time. This artifact demonstrates how I dismantle "technical anxiety" by ensuring students do not feel judged, creating an environment where they can "focus on storytelling" rather than the fear of failure
- Below is the slide of mood check in I use in class (e.g., the "Blob Tree" or the slide asking "What is your mental weather?"). It addresses the "Affective Classroom" section where you mention: *"I implement 'Mood and Thought Check-ins'... diagnostic tools that acknowledge learning as an affective process."*
- **Context:** All classes in the past two years.



Selected Artifacts with Annotations

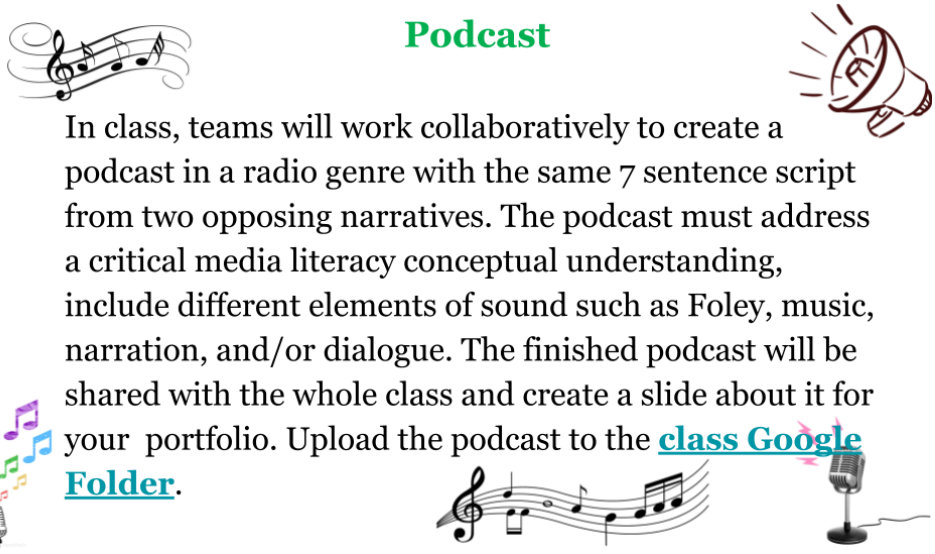
Arpit Gaind, PhD Candidate

Cluster 10, Data Justice and Society

Program Coordinator: Prof. Miriam Posner

Artifact 2: Active Knowledge Construction – "Sound and Power" Module

- **Connection to Statement:** This artifact, referenced in the "Affective Classroom" section, illustrates my commitment to treating the classroom as a "rehearsal space." Rather than lecturing on media manipulation, this activity requires students to enact it. By editing a raw clip into two opposing narratives solely through sound design, students move from passive consumption to active creation, using technical tools as "palettes for their own stories."
- Below is the slide handout with the instructions for the podcast/audio play editing task. It addresses the specific example: *"During a module on 'Sound and Power'... I pivoted to an impromptu activity where students edited a raw interview clip into two opposing narratives..."*
- **Context:** 10CW: Critical Media Literacy (Seminar).



Selected Artifacts with Annotations

Arpit Gaind, PhD Candidate

Cluster 10, Data Justice and Society

Program Coordinator: Prof. Miriam Posner

Artifact 3: The "Keyhole Diagram" Handout

- **Connection to Statement:** As noted in the "Collaborative Praxis" section, this artifact represents the outcome of my collaboration with the Cluster Writing Instruction team. It serves as a structural heuristic to help students "visualize their arguments." By integrating this tool, I provide the scaffolding students need to transition from vague ideas to rigorous academic structures, directly addressing the need for fine-tuned methods developed through peer observation.
- Below is the Keyhole Diagram and the descriptive explannatioon of it (screenshot). It addresses the "Collaborative Praxis" section: *"Collaborated with the writing team to integrate the 'Keyhole Diagram,' a structural heuristic..."*
- **Context**: UCLA Cluster Program (Writing Scaffolding).



The Keyhole Diagram

Introduction Paragraph (required exactly like this):
- Thesis statement (one sentence)
- Statement of Problem (one to three)
  - Type A) The problems the texts designate
  - Type B) The problems you as author are showing
- Statement of Solution (one to three)
  - Type A) The solutions the texts designate
  - Type B) The solutions you as author are showing
- Significance Statements (one to three)
- Scope (what the writer will do in the order they will do it; sometimes a new/second paragraph)

Body:
- Paragraphs begin with Topic Sentence (no quotes)
- Paragraphs end with Significance Statements (why was this paragraph important, or how did paragraph's content link to Section Topic or Paper Thesis)

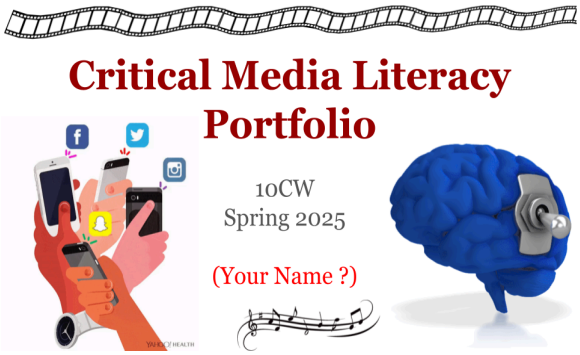
Conclusion:
Introduction in reverse, paraphrased:
- Scope
- Significance
- Solution
- Problem
- Thesis

Selected Artifacts with Annotations

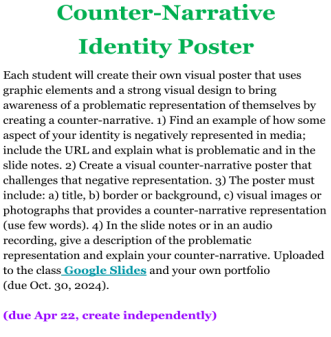
Arpit Gaind, PhD Candidate
Cluster 10, Data Justice and Society
Program Coordinator: Prof. Miriam Posner

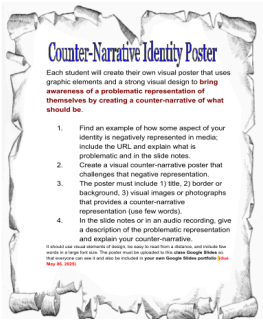
Artifact 4: Public Scholarship Assessment – Digital Portfolios & Reflections

- **Connection to Statement:** The artifacts demonstrates my method of "Scaffolding Public Scholarship." As detailed in my statement, I assess student learning not through traditional exams, but through the creation of Digital Portfolios Slides Deck that enact the "politics of representation." The inclusion of the Exit Reflection essay ensures that students engage in metacognitive analysis of their own work, bridging the gap between technical production and theoretical critique.
- **The like and screenshots below are from a range of in-class and assignment bassed activities including the** Spring 2025 Seminar (Final Project). addresses the specific line: *"...guiding students in creating comprehensive Digital Portfolios for their finals, complementing this with exit reflection essays..."*
- Context: Spring 2025 Seminar





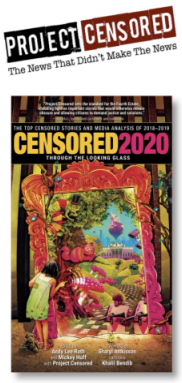




Project Censored

Validated Independent News Story (VINs)

1. Find a story
2. Evaluate the story's strength
   a) Is it important?
   b) Is it timely?
   c) Is it fact-based and well documented?
   d) Have the corporate media ignored or underreported the story?
3. Summarize the story
4. Include References

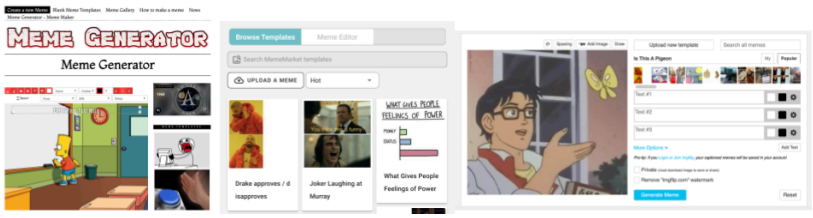


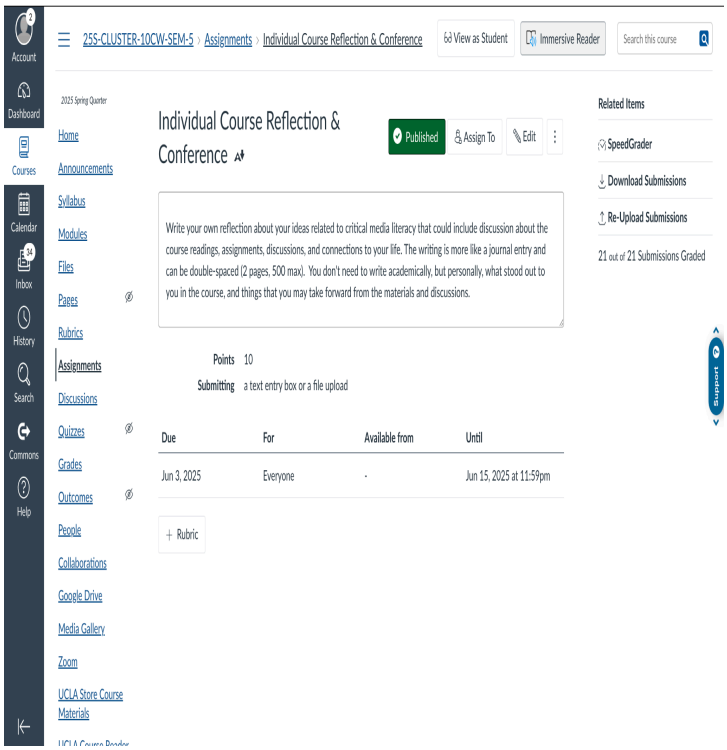
The Write-Up

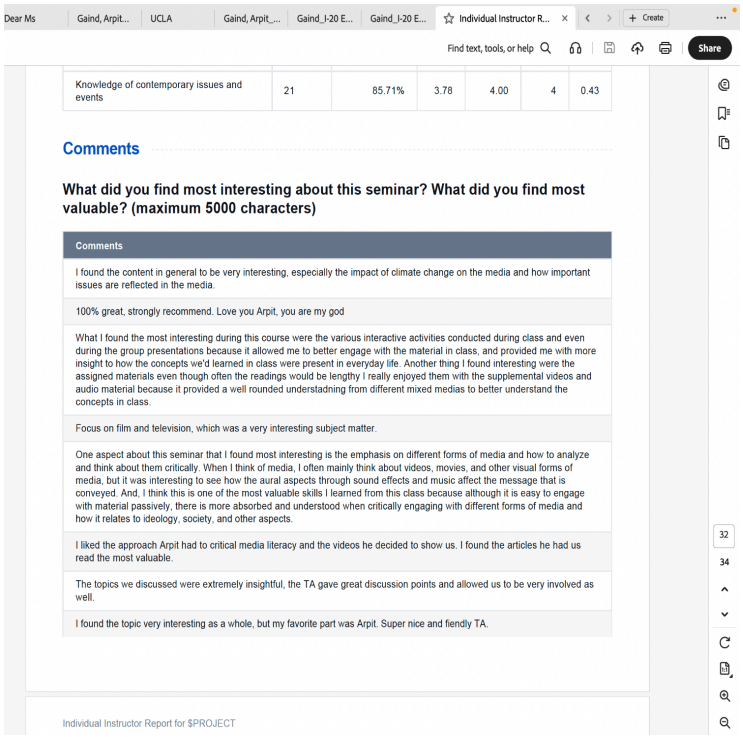
1. Title (5-10 words)
2. Summary (250-400 words)
   a) 1st paragraph: specific, concise, and factual summary of the most important parts
   b) 2nd paragraph: more detail
   c) 3rd paragraph: corporate media coverage of the story
3. References
   a) *Chicago Manual of Style*

Media Myth Busting Meme

Media Myth Busting Meme: **In class** you will create memes with a partner that critique a dominant ideology by re-contextualizing it in a way that reveals the fallacy. Upload it to this Google Slides and include it in your digital portfolio. There are many websites to create and generate memes, and this website to understand them: *Know Your Meme*. Be sure to include the names of everyone who created the meme in the notes below it.







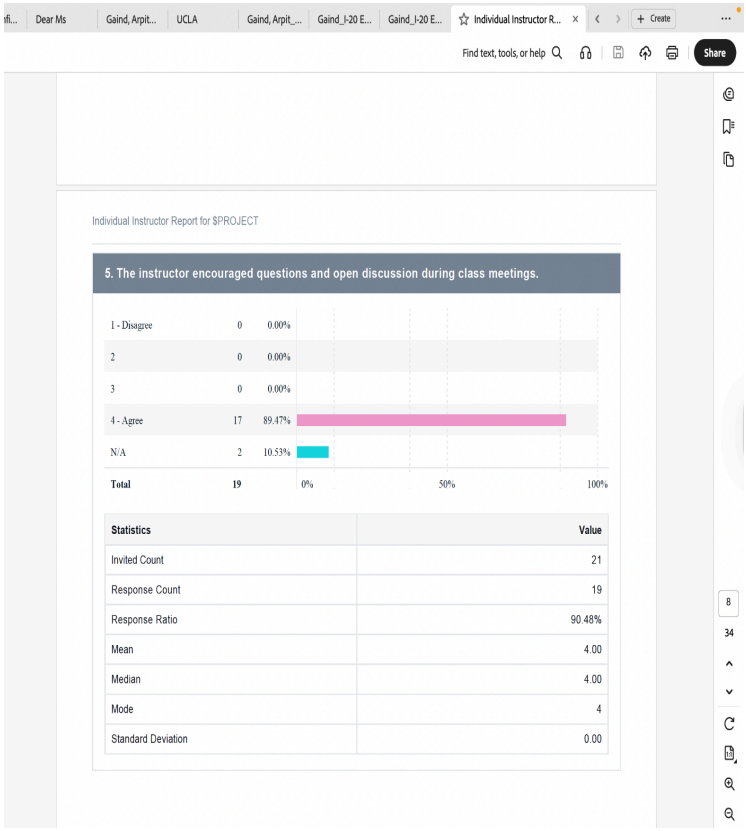
Knowledge of contemporary issues and events	21	85.71%	3.78	4.00	4	0.43

Comments

What did you find most interesting about this seminar? What did you find most valuable? (maximum 5000 characters)

Comments
I found the content in general to be very interesting, especially the impact of climate change on the media and how important issues are reflected in the media.
100% great, strongly recommend. Love you Arpit, you are my god
What I found the most interesting during this course were the various interactive activities conducted during class and even during the group presentations because it allowed me to better engage with the material in class, and provided me with more insight to how the concepts we'd learned in class were present in everyday life. Another thing I found interesting were the assigned materials even though often the readings would be lengthy I really enjoyed them with the supplemental videos and audio material because it provided a well rounded understadning from different mixed medias to better understand the concepts in class.
Focus on film and television, which was a very interesting subject matter.
One aspect about this seminar that I found most interesting is the emphasis on different forms of media and how to analyze and think about them critically. When I think of media, I often mainly think about videos, movies, and other visual forms of media, but it was interesting to see how the aural aspects through sound effects and music affect the message that is conveyed. And, I think this is one of the most valuable skills I learned from this class because although it is easy to engage with material passively, there is more absorbed and understood when critically engaging with different forms of media and how it relates to ideology, society, and other aspects.
I liked the approach Arpit had to critical media literacy and the videos he decided to show us. I found the articles he had us read the most valuable.
The topics we discussed were extremely insightful, the TA gave great discussion points and allowed us to be very involved as well.
I found the topic very interesting as a whole, but my favorite part was Arpit. Super nice and fiendly TA.

Individual Instructor Report for $PROJECT



Individual Instructor Report for $PROJECT

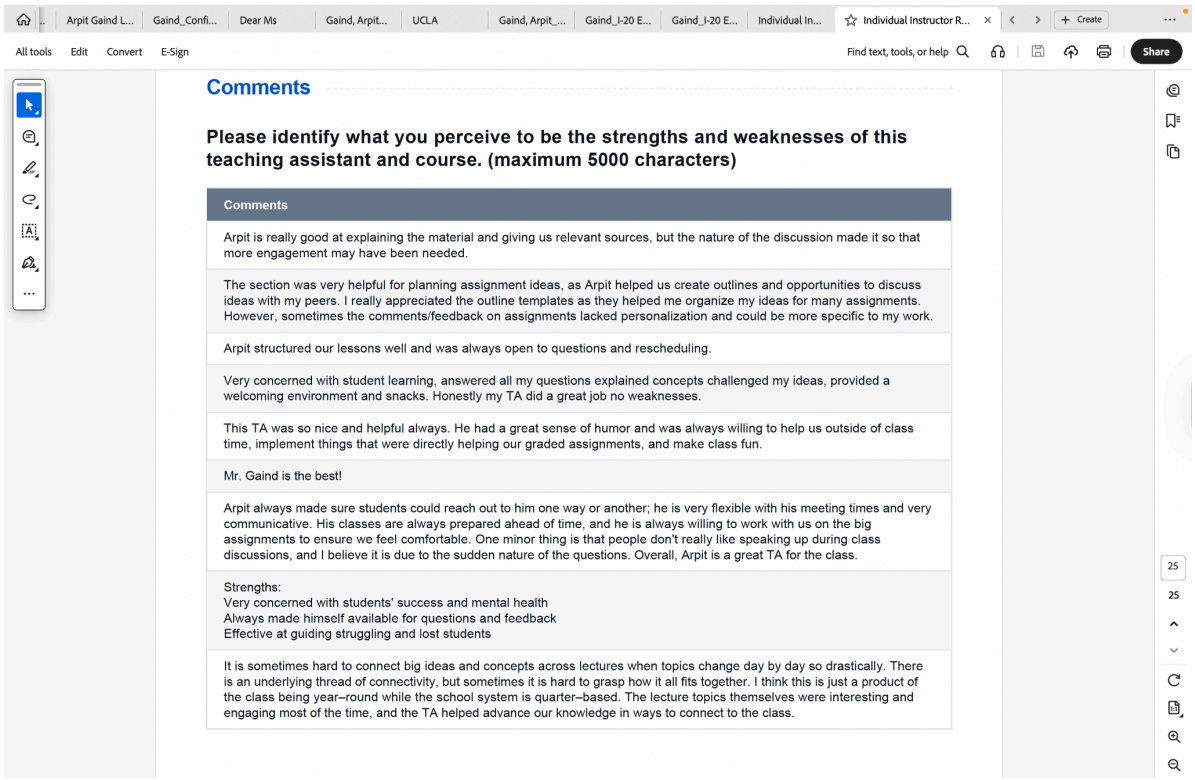
5. The instructor encouraged questions and open discussion during class meetings.

1 - Disagree	0	0.00%	
2	0	0.00%	
3	0	0.00%	
4 - Agree	17	89.47%	
N/A	2	10.53%	
Total	**19**		

0% 50% 100%

Statistics	Value
Invited Count	21
Response Count	19
Response Ratio	90.48%
Mean	4.00
Median	4.00
Mode	4
Standard Deviation	0.00

Comments
I thought analyzing different pieces of literacy from different lenses was interesting.
I thought that the different topics each week were the most interesting about this seminar and kept me engaged. I found the skills we were taught most valuable.
I found this seminar to be incredibly enlightening and relevant to the world today. Arpit made the seminar very welcoming; connecting students together through group work, a friendly environment, and engaging conversation. The subject of Critical Media Literacy is one that may sound boring or unneeded at first, but Arpit was able to show the subject's relevance and help student develop the necessary skill. CML is something many people may do subconsciously already, yet it takes this course to depend one's skill. This skill allows media consumers–essentially everyone––to distinguish between ideologies produced and pursued by the creator and by the consumer themselves. Overall, this course was surprisingly informative and under Aprit's instructions the course was very enjoyable despite the three hour–long classes.
I chose the seminar for critical media literacy as I had never taken this class before, and I saw an open opportunity to learn something knew. I never knew that CML class was so crucial as part of education, and now that I can successfully understand media around me, I can think more critically and analytically of things around me. Be it a movie, daily conversations, etc. I find the knowledge gained most valuable that I shall carry forward.
What I found most interesting about this seminar was the opportunity to experiment with different forms of media and understand how the choices behind their production influence people's perception of them. This type of knowledge is very valuable considering the massive amount of information we're faced with daily.
I found that the most interesting and valuable thing about this seminar is the relevance in today's world as we live in a very digital world where we are presented with so much information. It made me confront my biases and critically think about the media I confront on a daily. I also like how we talked about specific topics like AI and environmental science.
I liked the way that everything was framed and how it related to our world.



Selected Artifacts with Annotations

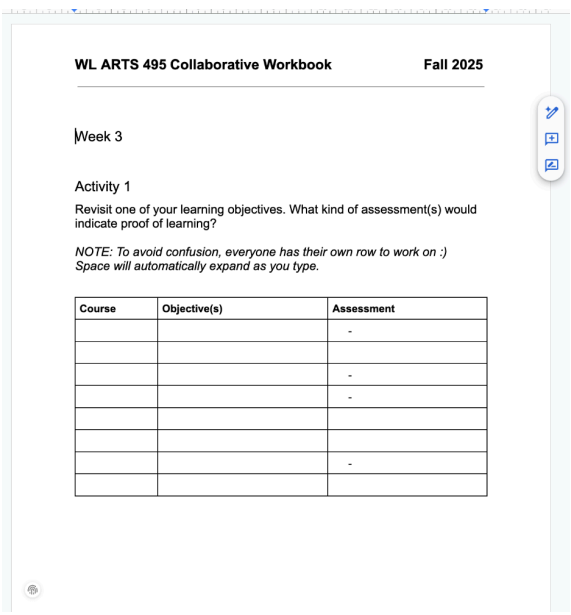
Arpit Gaind, PhD Candidate

Cluster 10, Data Justice and Society

Program Coordinator: Prof. Miriam Posner

Artifact 5: Institutional Leadership – TAC Workshop Materials

- **Connection to Statement:** This artifact illustrates my "Institutional Leadership" beyond the classroom. It is drawn from the mentorship workshops I designed to help incoming TAs "facilitate difficult conversations" and manage classroom dynamics. By demystifying the "hidden curriculum" of academic instruction, I ensure that new instructors feel capable and supported, extending my pedagogical philosophy to the department as a whole.
- Below are the slides and screenshot of templates and rubric from the classes I tookw ith the incoming TA about managing classroom dynamics. Addresses the "Institutional Leadership" section: *"...mentor incoming TAs on facilitating difficult conversations. This mentorship has proven vital..."*
- **Context:** Fall 2025, departmental Teaching Assistant Consultant (TAC) Training (2025-26).



WL ARTS 495 Collaborative Workbook **Fall 2025**

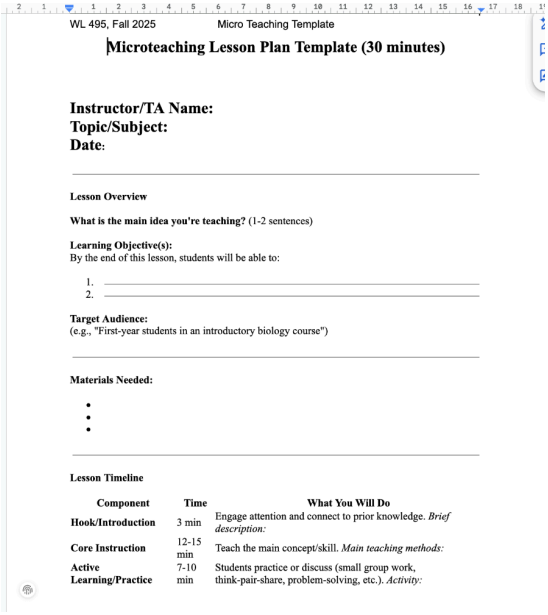
Week 3

Activity 1

Revisit one of your learning objectives. What kind of assessment(s) would indicate proof of learning?

NOTE: To avoid confusion, everyone has their own row to work on :)
Space will automatically expand as you type.

Course	Objective(s)	Assessment
		-
		-
		-
		-



WL 495, Fall 2025 Micro Teaching Template

Microteaching Lesson Plan Template (30 minutes)

Instructor/TA Name:
Topic/Subject:
Date:

Lesson Overview

What is the main idea you're teaching? (1-2 sentences)

Learning Objective(s):
By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. _____
2. _____

Target Audience:
(e.g., "First-year students in an introductory biology course")

Materials Needed:

-
-
-

Lesson Timeline

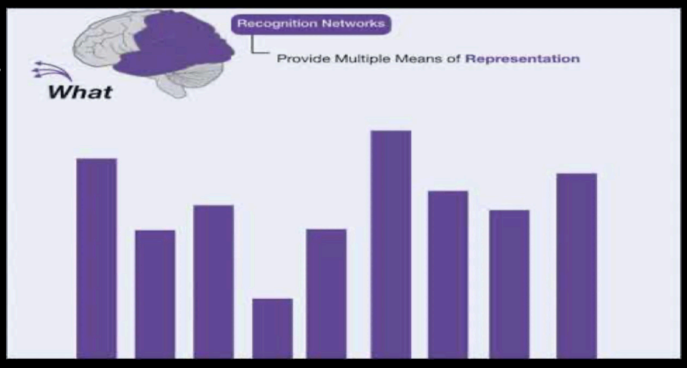
Component	Time	What You Will Do
Hook/Introduction	3 min	Engage attention and connect to prior knowledge. *Brief description:*
Core Instruction	12-15 min	Teach the main concept/skill. *Main teaching methods:*
Active Learning/Practice	7-10 min	Students practice or discuss (small group work, think-pair-share, problem-solving, etc.). *Activity:*

FOSTERING BELONGING IN THE CLASSROOM – UCLA STATISTICS

- According to the 2024 University of California Undergraduate Experience Survey (UCUES), 85% of undergraduate students reported some level of agreement with the statement that they feel a sense of belonging at the institutional level.
- Additionally, 76% of respondents reported feeling valued as individuals by the university. Similarly, 85% and 84% of graduate students surveyed in 2023 at least "somewhat agree" that they belong at UCLA and their graduate programs, respectively.
- Around 15% of all students report feeling a lack of belonging or perceive that they are not valued by the institution.
- What does this mean: In a class of 200 undergraduates, at least 30 students feel alienated from the university, their instructor, or their peers, underscoring the ongoing need for inclusive teaching practices.
-

SCAFFOLDING LEARNING EXPERIENCES – PEDAGOGICAL PRACTICES AND UNIVERSAL DESIGN FOR LEARNING

-



TA/Instructor Reflection Form
Complete this form after receiving your peer feedback.
This feedback can be used to help you draft your teaching statement.

1) What have I learned? What will I consider as result of this feedback?

2) What will I do differently next time?

3) Why will I make these changes?

4) What are some possible next steps to take with students?

[Name]
WL ARTS 495
Fall 2025
[Submission Date]

Teaching Philosophy

Although there is no formula for writing a Teaching Philosophy, consider answering these questions to start and organize your statement:

1. **What are the learning objectives that you set for your students?** What do you want students to learn in your class? (skills-based? Concept-based or knowledge-based?) These should span the scope of all classes you've taught.
2. **How does learning happen in my classroom?** What kinds of activities do I do in the classroom to help students learn?
3. **How do I know that students are learning what I wanted them to learn?**

In the introduction, identify those 3 learning objectives that you want students to learn. Then include a couple of paragraphs for each objective to say why the objective is important, how you teach that objective, and how you measure student learning.

- Introduction: Outlining
- A paragraph or two on each learning objective 1, 2, and 3
- You can include additional thoughts on what you are passionate about in the opening paragraph. Stating your commitment to inclusive classrooms and how you articulate that in the classroom.
- Closing paragraph: tie back to that idea–personal vision for the classroom

Introduction

Learning Objectives

1. [Description]
2. [Description]
3. [Description]

Conclusion

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name i

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

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Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

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Name Hongda Qi

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

I first met Arpit during my discussion for Cluster 10A: Data, Justice, and Society. In that section, I really liked his style of teaching and explaining class-related topics, so I enrolled in his discussion section for Cluster 10B this quarter. He has been my TA for the last two quarters.

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

To me, Arpit really stands out because he pays attention to the well-being of everyone in class. When I first walked into the discussion, I saw a slide full of cats–happy ones, tired ones, hungry ones… He takes attendance by having us fill out a Google form saying which cat matched our mood. If he saw that we were tired or stressed, he would ask us what was wrong and comfort us. If he saw that we were hungry, he may bring us snacks next time.

I deeply value Arpit's care to us all because it makes me feel motivated to keep learning after a long day. Arpit's patience is also very helpful to learning. When there is something that we did not understand from lecture, Arpit will teach it to us again by combining educational videos with personal insights. Then, he'd ask us questions to guide us through the thinking process. If we still did not understand, he would patiently answer every question we had. When

we were doing work, he would walk around the classroom, constantly checking in to make sure we were doing well. IIn short, Arpit is a wonderful teacher who inspires us to learn more.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

We all came into the cluster with different backgrounds and levels of knowledge. Thus, everyone understood material at different paces. Arpit would help us by having us form small groups where we could share our expertise with one another. In my group, there was a data science student who explained to us the more technical aspects of LLMs and how they interact with data. I, a public health major, used this knowledge to explain the health impacts of big data. We were given discussion questions, which we first talked about in our groups and then shared with the class. This way, everyone was able to be brought up to speed on the course knowledge.

There were also times when we completed projects at different paces. Then, Arpit would have us form into groups with people who were at the same stage as we were. We would then bounce ideas off of each other and help each other progress to the next stage. In all of this, Arpit was ready to jump in and help us if needed. Moreover, we were able to form many close friendships through these groups. They truly made the discussion much more fun and engaging.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Arpit is a wonderful friend to all of us who will go beyond his way to help us in whatever way he could. Whether it be setting up extra office hours during weekends to help us with projects or bringing us banana bread during finals season to cheer us up, he really makes us feel we belong. In a school of 33,000 undergraduates, it can be really hard to find a community to call home. Arpit, however, has made the discussion section a place we could come to to learn, socialize, and feel at home.

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February 10, 2026

Dear DTA Selection Committee:

It is a privilege to write in support of Arpit Gaind for the Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award. I got to know Arpit last year (2024-25) when he took a series of pedagogy seminars dedicated to new Clusters TAs. The Teaching Fellows who work in the Cluster Program have a demanding charge: to teach writing in the disciplines while helping students understand course content that may be in a completely different field from their home department. Unsurprisingly, Arpit responded to this challenge with his trademark combination of rigor and thoughtfulness. He has the ability to create learning environments where students want to participate and where their ideas are taken seriously. When I observed his seminar, "Politics of Visual Representation," in April 2025, I experienced an engaged, collaborative community with Arpit highlighting specific successes in their completed Critical Media assignment while also creating space for students to share their own insights after working through the assignment. Arpit builds true student-centered learning environments where his students thrive.

A clear highlight was the creativity Arpit injected into the classwork. Small groups went into the podcast tab of the library research guide for the class, picked a podcast relevant to the class topic (use of sound in the production of meaning), and then "pitched" it to everyone after posting it to a class Padlet. This work came after careful set up through an all class discussion of the importance of sound in media and analysis of several videos Arpit screened for the class to deconstruct collectively. Each component tied together seamlessly, building to the successful pitch activity. Thus, students were working in different modalities, considering different audience needs, and contributing to a class resource they could use for the upcoming assignment. The work was fun yet focused on skill-building and thinking more critically about the media we consume. And students clearly trusted Arpit's guidance as he nudged groups to think more deeply and to connect directly to concepts under discussion. This is an activity I would adapt into my own classroom, that's how productive it was. Arpit's seminar showcased his ability to create a dynamic learning environment *with* his students. It seemed effortless, but I know Arpit had carefully lesson planned to achieve the epiphanies he sparked in his students. It was impressive.

Every teaching choice Arpit makes leads his students to become empowered, more creative thinkers and writers. He is a passionate, dedicated instructor whose commitment to student success should earn him this award.

Sincerely,
Margaret Davis
Margaret Davis (Peggy)

Senior Continuing Lecturer, UCLA Writing Programs
Writing Advisor, UCLA Clusters Program